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All-remote enables unconventional living situations where travel is a core pillar. Tynan, once a digital nomad who now maintains a residence in Las Vegas, Nevada, orchestrated a multi-year strategy to acquire part ownership in a handful of properties around the world.

This affords him multiple home bases around the world for less than the cost of an average property in a major global city. He details this approach, which is replicable by those with a core group of like-minded friends, in a series of blog posts.

1. My Friends and I Bought an Island

1. An Island, Vegas, Budapest for A Fraction of the Median House Price

1. Building an Island Cabin

1. My Friends and I Bought a Condo in Hawaii

1. What It's Like Sharing Properties With Friends
1. How to Love Living in Las Vegas
1. How I Decided to Move to Las Vegas In 12 Hours

Parents

{{< youtube "MZc0HazaX4?start=382" >}}

> I'm definitely spending more time with my children, which they appreciate and I really enjoy. I've always wanted flexibility, but [GitLab] is a place where it's not just lip service. You can live it. - Melody M., Accounting and External Reporting Manager at GitLab

Building a career while raising one or more children has its challenges. However, all-remote and remote-first organizations provide an atmosphere where those who yearn to continue working may do so without the usual family sacrifices linked to daily commutes in colocated environments.

Research has shown that parental presence for infants, toddlers, and older children has a marked impact on a child's adaptability and aptitude. In high-income families, it's easier for one parent to voluntarily step away from work to care for a child, with another parent supporting the group financially. This creates an outsized negative impact on lower-income families, including those residing in rural areas where well-paying colocated career opportunities are limited.

Boosting inclusion and diversity

Historically, this has also disproportionality impacted females, though The Pew Research Center has seen a recent rise in stay-at-home fathers citing "caring for home/family" as their reason.

All-remote solves these quandaries in multiple ways. In families where both parents wish to continue building their career, but desire to parent their child or children at home, an all-remote work environment affords them that luxury. Extrapolated, this contributes to a future generation of adults that have collectively reaped the benefits of increased parental presence, building a better tomorrow for all.

Improving quality of life

In cases where one parent desires to step away from work in order to focus completely on childrearing, all-remote makes it far easier for the family to relocate to an area with a lower cost-of-living and/or a higher quality of life (development opportunities, medical facilities, schools, etc.), such that one working parent can sustain the group financially.

While this provides clear and quantifiable benefits to the family, it also creates an economic boost to the community in which they relocate to.

Adoption and foster care

All-remote can significantly impact the fabric of a family in the process of adoption or fostering. In such cases, it is often imperative that a family be available in the home in order to finalize the adoption of a child or welcome a foster child into one's home. Beyond

all-remote work environments supporting more diverse and inclusive ways to start or build one's family, this creates more opportunity to aid the vulnerable and build a better future for all.

> My wife and I experienced the beautiful and transformative journey of adoption because I worked for an employer that trusted me to excel from a place I needed to be to see it through. I've met countless GitLabbers who have never been happier, more fulfilled, or more engaged with their family and community, because they're empowered to work remotely. - Darren M., Head of Remote

For more, consider reading GitLab's four-part blog series on working remotely with children of all ages.

1. Parental/maternity leave around the world · how does your country stack up?
1. How I balance a baby, a career at GitLab, and cultural expectations of motherhood
1. How to make your home a space that works with kids
1. 5 Things to keep in mind while working remotely with kids

Community advocates

{{< youtube "BC7Prkm3v3g" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of living in a lower cost-of-living environment near friends, family, and community.

It's not uncommon for individuals to feel a strong connection to the region where they were born, or a region which has contributed significantly to their development and worldview. Increasingly, those who feel a sense of connection to a rural area where they were raised are faced with a difficult choice: remain physically located in a community that matters to them despite underwhelming colocated career options, or uproot their life and move to an area which offers superior job opportunities.

Reversing rural depopulation

Research from the University of New Hampshire has found that "35% of rural counties in the United States are experiencing protracted and significant population loss."

Speaking to shrinking towns across Europe, a 2016 report from the European Parliamentary Research Service⁵⁸⁶⁶³²) notes that "younger members of society prefer to migrate to more economically vibrant regions and cities in search of better job prospects as, in most of these territories, professional opportunities remain limited and confined to specific fields (e.g. agriculture and tourism)."

All-remote has the power to pause, and perhaps even reverse, these trends of depopulation, by decoupling location and career opportunity.

Career portability

In scenarios where a couple desires to live together, one typically forgoes their existing career in order to relocate. With all-remote, careers are portable, enabling these milestone moments in life to be more momentous and less stressful.

In situations where parents desire to be closer to extended family or friends in order to share the responsibility of child rearing with a broader community, all-remote supports such endeavours by default.

Military spouses and families

Military rotations often require families to uproot and relocate on a regular basis. For military spouses and family members, this creates a significant burden. Being forced to restart one's career and reestablishing a rapport every couple of years is both inefficient and draining.

In many cases, the challenge is so significant that military spouses simply opt out of the workplace, despite a desire to further their career. This can lead to diminished economic potential for a family, and place increased strain on the military member to sustain the group.

All-remote is an ideal anecdote. Even as relocations occur, an all-remote team member can still contribute their insights and knowledge for the betterment of the company. This can create increased loyalty and lower turnover for all-remote employers, while supporting hiring pipelines which are more diverse and inclusive.

At GitLab, several team members are US military spouses.

Emilie S., a data engineer, provides tips for those embracing all-remote roles in a Doist blog post entitled "6 People Who Prove You Don't Have to Sacrifice Your Career to Work Remotely."

> Getting promoted while working remotely really depends on how remote your company is. GitLab is a fully remote organization with over 700 folks around the world, so getting promoted wasn't difficult at all. In previous roles, I was the only person who worked remotely. In those cases, I felt very forgotten by my employer. - Emilie S., data engineer at GitLab

Brittany R., Compensation & Benefits Manager, shares advice for working parents in an all-remote setting.

> My daughter is my best friend, and I am so blessed to be able to see her grow into her own little person while still accomplishing my professional goals. Seeing her interact ("Hi!" for everyone) with all of my GitLab teammates at Contribute was also very special. · Brittany R., Compensation & Benefits Manager

Hobbyists

Maintaining one or more hobbies is far easier in an all-remote setting. Traveling band members, boaters, and scuba divers are able to carry their work with them as they move from place to place.

Those who are drawn to outdoor hobbies, such as canyoneering, photography, rafting, and water sports, are more easily able to live in locales where these activities are feasible. In many cases, communities surrounded by vast expanses of nature are not within commuting distance to well-paying careers in major metropolitan areas. All-remote prevents one from having to sacrifice those elements for the sake of their career.

Those who value flexibility and autonomy

When considering employment of any kind, it's important to evaluate the offer in totality. Elements such as compensation, safety/security, management style, day-to-day tasks, and benefits are important. For some, the elements of flexibility, autonomy, and ability to live in a place of their choosing takes precedence.

It's wise to rank all of the above in order of importance for you. If you find that being able to live wherever you wish is as important, if not more important, than extracting a certain salary from a role, all-remote will likely suit you well.

Eldridge H., a support engineer at GitLab, articulates this below.

- > It dawned on me just how liberating remote work with GitLab is. It's a bit difficult to fully explain, but having my own personal space to work from is amazing.
- >
- > Having my own personal environment to work in, and being able to make this space my own, really motivates me to do well. The freedom I have to make choices on how I approach things and at the same time, being empowered to communicate with others and adapt their approaches is insanely thought provoking.
- >
- > Even though everyone is remote, it's just like being in an office with everyone. It's so reassuring how motivated, caring, and diligent everyone is. It's insane how there are so many of us, but the whole process from ticket first response to resolution makes it seem like we are all in the same location.
- >
- > It's so cool to be surrounded by extremely smart and motivated people. To be able to troubleshoot and talk about nerdy things without fear. It's reassuring to know that we all have the same goal in mind. The autonomy to communicate with who we need to, in our own personal space, really shows me how valuable we are as a team.
- >
- > GitLab Support is hard. It's challenging and immensely rewarding. It's confusing and scary. However, it is comforting to know that everyone feels this way.
- >
- > I expected remote work to be a hurdle to overcome upon joining GitLab. I wondered how having the filter of a webcam would impact people and how they reacted or interacted. These questions were squashed after my first day. I am extremely happy to have been given this insane opportunity. To make things better for others and at the same time, make things better for myself. We are like an open source community within an open source community.

Employer benefits

Employers should recognize that this reality also benefits them. When you hire individuals who place a high degree of value on not having to commute and being able to live and work where they're most comfortable, they will generally hold the company in higher regard, find greater connection with their work, and exhibit greater loyalty. Research by TINYpulse and Owl Labs found that "companies that support remote work have a 25% higher retention rate than companies that don't."

Work/life harmony

{{< youtube "2yN2vBxo7as" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of all-remote, including the ability to keep one's health as a top priority while working atypical schedules when necessary.

The traditional view of work/life balance insinuates that work and life are on opposite ends of a scale, with an individual responsible for ensuring that neither side teeters too far in one direction. This creates a climate where work and life are naturally at odds with one another, ever at war for the hours in your day.

A healthier approach, enabled by all-remote, is work/life harmony. When your work and your life are in harmony, there's less friction. You're free to approach your day not as a competition between two factions, but as one experience with two forces that more naturally give and take as needed.

Added adaptability

All-remote enables greater harmony by being more forgiving of the unknown, and more accepting of the unexpected. When you're able to live and work in a place of your choosing, there's one less barrier in the way when you need to quickly pivot away from work in order to address a situation at home, with family, etc.

Creating a more efficient day

It also allows you to weave the common chores of life into one's working day. Tasks such as laundry, collecting mail, exercising, cooking/preparing meals, finding private space for sensitive phone calls (e.g. calls to a financial institution), and even napping can be accomplished during short breaks in the day for someone who is able to work at home.

This creates tremendous efficiency, and can easily add one to two hours of leisure time back to a worker's day. If forced to endure a commute and be away from home in a colocated working arrangement, all of the aforesaid tasks would need to be handled after office hours, creating unhealthy competition between work and life.

Adjustable working hours

An added benefit to being a manager of one and working in an environment that supports asynchronous communication is the ability to shift one's working day to accommodate important life moments.

All-remote enables individuals to be available during daylight hours for activities such as volunteering, participating in school functions, and managing tasks that cannot be handled in off-hours (e.g. renewing a driver license, certain banking functions, etc.).

For those with chronic illnesses, where frequent visits to a doctor are required, the flexibility could be the difference between being able to maintain a career, and being forced to either drop out of the workforce or pursue a part-time position.

Employees who are entrusted to manage their days, balancing the demands of life with the

requirements of work, are more likely to exist in a harmonious state.

The spoils of an off-peak life

All-remote also allows individuals to operate their life in an off-peak manner. For instance, those in a conventional colocated corporate setting may have little choice but to plan a family trip to a national park over a holiday in order to minimize time away from the office. This all but guarantees negative financial consequences (paying peak rates for travel and lodging) and an underwhelming experience (attempting to access a popular destination with throngs of others).

When you're able to adjust your working hours and days, it's easier to plan travel on days with fewer businesspeople competing for seats, aiming for Tuesday, Wednesday, and Saturday and avoiding Sunday, Monday, and Friday.

It's easier to save money by enjoying activities when crowds are down, such as taking in a sporting event on a Wednesday afternoon as opposed to a Friday or Saturday evening.

It's easier to create special moments for your family, visiting a desirable restaurant, park, or venue during off-peak hours as opposed to battling crowds.

Caretakers

All-remote allows individuals to live close to friends and family should they choose. This is of particular significance to individuals who need or desire to act as a caregiver. For instance, those with aging parents may prefer to move nearby and assist with daily needs rather than considering placement in a care facility. This can have major emotional and financial benefits.

As time passes, caregiving needs can change. Families may need to relocate to be closer to one family for a time, then relocate again as a different family member ages. All-remote allows individuals to carry their career with them, relieving caregivers of the burden of choosing their job over family.

Beyond the personal, communal, and societal benefits from empowering people to provide care to others who are important to them, all-remote employers should expect heightened loyalty and job satisfaction from caregiving team members.

> When we made the decision to relocate to help care for my dad, it was a huge relief to know I didn't have to worry about the move impacting my career. The asynchronous nature of our work also means I have the freedom to shape my days and weeks to prioritize time with my parents. Being part of the GitLab team gives me invaluable flexibility, support, and stability that benefits my entire family during this challenging chapter of life. - Betsy B., All-Remote Evangelist

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared

responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/phases-of-remote-adaptation.md

As teams grapple with transitioning from a colocated environment to a remote one, it's common to see differing levels of adaptability. For some, the transition is fairly smooth, as a remote-first infrastructure was already established. For others, the shift is thoroughly disruptive.

The amount of disruption is generally tied to two maturity factors: culture and tools.

To better understand this, we're using this page to detail the phases of remote adaptation.

- Phase 1: Skeuomorph
- Phase 2: Functional
- Phase 3: Asynchronous
- Phase 4: Intentionality

{{< youtube "ZTcj1nhGmfw" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, Darren (Head of Remote, GitLab) and Luke (Founder, Friday) unpack the phases of remote adaptation, and discuss projections for societal shifts related to remote work.

It's important to frame one's transition to remote in terms of phases, as opposed to an all-or-nothing approach. Breaking adaptation down into smaller chunks creates less overwhelm. The goal for any suddenly remote company should be to graduate from one phase to another in a sustainable and efficient manner, instead of what will otherwise feel like a massive leap from nothing to mastery. This is iteration in practice.

Phase 1: Skeuomorph

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<p>In Phase 1, a remote organization will look to imitate the design, structure, norms, ebbs and flows of an office environment. The primary goal is to merely continue to operate the business, but remotely.</p>
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<p>Like for like scenarios</p>
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<p>For example, a typical hallway conversation will become a one-on-one direct message, and a pre-</p>
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planned meeting at the office will be replaced by a video call with the same participants and preexisting meeting hygiene.

Organizations in Phase 1 will attempt to copy the in-office environment and paste it into a digital, remote environment. Replicating the in-office experience, remotely, is a telltale sign that an entity is in Phase 1 of remote adaptation. Here's how Sid Sijbrandij, GitLab co-founder, explains it:

> The first phase is this: instead of having your meeting in a conference room, you have it on Zoom. Your hallway chatter · instead of having it in a hallway, you have it on Slack. That's the first phase of remote. You're not taking advantage of what remote provides.

>

> In the second phase of remote, you use what remote enables. For example: instead of just having a meeting on Zoom, you also record it, so the people who couldn't be there [live] can still watch it.

>

> Instead of using Slack to have a direct message conversation with someone about work, you have it in a public channel so people get context.

The "Whiteboarding Fixation"

The inability to project beyond Phase 1 is crippling. An organization fixated on questions such as "How do I replicate the whiteboarding experience, remotely?" is failing to see the potential of later phases. The above question is not altogether useful. Focus on outcomes, not mediums. A better series of questions is as follows.

- Have we documented what positive outcomes came from conventional whiteboarding sessions in the office?
- Now that we are able to operate asynchronously, is there a more efficient, inclusive, and robust way to achieve the same positive outcomes?

A company which remains in Phase 1 indefinitely will struggle. While it is not practical to assume that all leaders will understand that there are different ways to achieve outcomes (referencing the aforementioned whiteboarding scenario), the simple act of asking the question and seeking new tools, processes, and expertise is a prerequisite to entering Phase 2 and beyond.

Learn more in GitLab's guide to remote collaboration and whiteboarding.

Recognizing opportunity

Most in-office procedures translate poorly to remote, but the more critical issue is this: remote creates an entirely new landscape in which to conduct business, and failing to maximize that opportunity will ensure that your business is less efficient than a competitor which moves into later phases.

Some businesses will choose not to invest time, energy, and resources to moving beyond Phase 1, declaring remote work a failure. These entities will place the bulk of their efforts in moving back into an office · going back to what they were accustomed to.

Phase 2: Functional

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Entering Phase 2 is simple. It begins with leadership asking a fundamental question: "What if we didn't do things the way we've always done them?"

Remote enables you to function differently than a conventional colocated company. It challenges preconceived notions and it provides new opportunities to increase efficiency of work and agency of people.

Evolving processes

Companies in Phase 2 will begin to take advantage of technology to replace things which were manually done, or not done at all. For example, a company will begin to:

- Record all meetings and automatically upload them, plugging knowledge gaps created by undocumented gatherings.
- Attach a Google Doc agenda to every business meeting, writing questions, answers, and conversation down in real-time as the meeting transpires so that knowledge is archived for reference, and for viewing by attendees who are not able to attend live.
- Converse about a work topic in a public chat channel instead of a private channel, so that more input may be gained.
- Documentation will occur in most instances, but there is no overarching guidance on how to document, where to contextualize takeaways, who to share documentation with, and how others will ever find anyone else's documentation.

Phase 3: Asynchronous

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Phase 3 is marked by a company's comfortability in completing work without mandated synchronicity.

Maximally efficient remote environments will do as little work as possible synchronously, instead focusing the valuable moments where two or more people are online at the same time on informal communication and bonding.

Embracing forcing functions

Synchronous actions aren't seen as bad or necessarily inferior, they simply are not the default. Instead, team members in a Phase 3 environment will do the following:

- Hatch an idea or ask for input in an issue tracker rather than a chat tool, meeting, email, or other private forum where information is immediately siloed and fragmented.
- Work handbook-first, thereby documenting protocols, updates, solutions, or guidance in a single source of truth first. Only after documentation occurs should dissemination occur, creating a culture where answering with a link is expected.

- Instead of simply having stacks of unsorted issues, you categorize in a systematic way using roadmaps and milestones.
- Expire your chat (Slack or Teams) messages after 90 days, creating a forcing function to only use Slack for informal communication, thereby creating a saner and healthier atmosphere.

Learn more in GitLab's guide to using forcing functions to work remote-first.

{{< youtube "CZ4nBzxPjNc?start=329" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, GitLab's Head of Remote discusses the topic of reenvisioning Slack's potential as an informal communication tool, and forcing functions to create a more asynchronous work environment. A portion of the discussion is transcribed below.

- > We expire all of our Slack messages after 90 days. So, nothing on Slack can be queried after 90 days. This serves as a forcing function for all work to begin where it needs to end up, which is in GitLab.
- >
- > Everyone understands that if you were to start a project in Slack, it wouldn't work out well for you, as you won't be able to search for any context or prior conversation after 90 days.
- >
- > This counteracts the human instinct to start a project in a chat tool. It forces us to ask a simple question: 'Where does the work need to end up?' (Answer: GitLab)
- >
- > This structure also solves another common problem with remote teams, which is people tend to feel isolated or disconnected from people. Given that we cannot practically use Slack for long-term work projects, we maximize its use as a tool for informal communication. Our team has access to a plethora of topical channels · fitness, music, mental health, parenting, etc.

Using GitLab for remote collaboration

Leadership can create a more humane atmosphere by leaning on a tool (or tools) that enable asynchronous workflows, thereby reducing meetings and creating more time for focused, deep work. GitLab uses GitLab to accomplish this.

GitLab is a collaboration tool designed to help people work better together whether they are in the same location or spread across multiple time zones. Originally, GitLab let software developers collaborate on writing code and packaging it up into software applications. Today, GitLab has a wide range of capabilities used by people around the globe in all kinds of companies and roles.

You can learn more at GitLab's remote team solutions page.

Phase 4: Intentionality

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<p>Phase 4 is marked by an extraordinary amount of intentionality, particularly in areas that are typically assumed to need minimal guardrails. The list below is not exhaustive, but showcases examples of this approach.</p>
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- Measuring output (impact) rather than input (activity). This requires a deliberate choice to not measure hours spent working, as well as a strong commitment to outlining deliverables and expectations that can be measured. This enables team members to work towards their goals in any manner they choose.
- Hiring outside of a company's home geography without relocating. By intentionally opening one's talent acquisition pipeline to the globe, you assume certain risks (time zone headaches, legal and regulatory hurdles in foreign nations, etc.) understanding that the ability to hire the world's best talent is worthwhile.
- Structure social interactions and non-work activities. While colocated companies allow fate to dictate these interactions, remote companies look to their people group to brainstorm ideas with functional leaders and put opportunities to gather as a team on the calendar.
- Create team building opportunities that are even grander than those in colocated spaces, such as team-wide talent shows, trivia events, show-and-tell gatherings, virtual lobbies for water-cooler conversation, global pizza parties/celebrations, and even global family-oriented chats.
- Divest real estate before you have to. Intentional remote companies will make deliberate moves to reduce real estate costs, relying on their ability to adapt in order to create a thriving remote work environment. In other words, there is a deliberate removal of the office safety net. When you sell your real estate, or stop leasing, you have no fallback · you must create a thriving remote atmosphere, and evolve it such that it remains a best-in-class workplace.

Maturity

{{< youtube "S197ok0lBtw?start=45" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, GitLab's Head of Remote discusses the topic of cultural maturity during an interview with Mårten Mickos, CEO of HackerOne.

An organization's ability to transition quickly from Phase 1 to Phase 3 is dependent on maturity. Consider the below questions, all of which will be important for suddenly-remote firms forming a remote leadership team.

Cultural maturity

- How mature is management, and are they willing to be transparent with their team on how they are iterating on-the-fly as they move between phases?
- Are managers naturally willing to adopt a mindset of trust and empowerment as opposed to command and control?
- Is there a natural inclination to open up a feedback mechanism to shape a company-wide transition, or is leadership's first instinct to implement strict rules and check-ins?
- Does management default to creating a single source of truth for processes and protocols, or are FAQs and communiques created behind closed doors and only by executives?
- Does management seek to listen to newly-remote team members to understand what voids exist and need to be addressed? Said another way, do they default to servant leadership in early phases of remote adaptation?
- Does management seek to maximize the advantages of a remote environment once stabilization occurs?

Technical maturity

- Do team members have a preexisting understanding of digital communication tools?
- Do team members have preexisting methods of accessing sensitive information (e.g. established VPN protocols)?
- Does a company's business operations or IT department have preexisting protocols for enabling team members from locales outside of the office?
- Does a company have preexisting documentation for core company processes (communication, client service expectations, socializing and relationship building, onboarding, in-person interactions, expensing, working hours, metrics and goals, owners/DRIs, etc.)

GitLab Knowledge Assessment: Phases of Remote Adaptation

Anyone can test their knowledge on the phases of remote adaptation by completing the knowledge assessment. Earn at least an 80% or higher on the assessment to receive a passing score. Once the quiz has been passed, you will receive an email acknowledging the completion from GitLab. We are in the process of designing a GitLab Remote Certification and completion of the assessment will be one requirement in obtaining the certification. If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

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Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/pick-your-brain.md

On this page, we're detailing how the public can request a Pick Your Brain interview focused on all-remote.

Why we offer public interviews on all-remote

{{< youtube "cy6WGuzArgY" >}}

An example of an All-Remote Pick Your Brain is embedded above, and can also be seen on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.

Emna G., founder and CEO at Veamly, speaks with GitLab's Darren M. on a number of remote work topics: reinforcing culture, encouraging work-life harmony, remote work processes, the importance of process optimization in team productivity, and asynchronous communication.

GitLab believes that everyone can contribute. We also believe that all-remote organizations can

fundamentally change the world by offering a different way to work. From reversing rural depopulation to providing opportunity to a more diverse set of people, we want all-remote to become less the exception, and more the norm.

There is no formal guidebook on building an all-remote company, and what works for a new startup may not map precisely to a larger organization.

While we are proponents of all-remote, we recognize that there are drawbacks as well as individuals who are skeptical about its feasibility. We embrace detractors and those who are inquisitive about making all-remote work. We're interested in hearing about challenges faced by others implementing remote work, so we can ideally find and document solutions.

Scheduling a Pick Your Brain interview on all-remote

Requests for interviews concerning advice on all-remote may be initiated by completing and submitting this Google Form. In the request, please include a brief overview of topics you hope to discuss, along with key questions you're prepared to ask.

These 20 to 30 minute interviews with GitLab's Head of Remote will be recorded though Zoom and shared on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.

We invite guests to surface challenges and examples as points of discussion. Post-interview, and where applicable, we will iterate on relevant handbook pages to document questions and solutions.

GitLab is a very transparent company and many things that are normally confidential can be found in our handbook, available online. Please consider looking at the following pages prior to the meeting.

1. GitLab's All-Remote Culture

1. Defining "all-remote"

1. Advantages

1. Disadvantages

1. Remote work fast boot and emergency plan for teams/leaders

1. Remote work starter guide for employees

1. Phases of remote adaptation

1. Being a great remote manager

1. How to evaluate a remote job

1. Getting started in a new remote job

1. Scaling a remote company

1. People

1. Non-linear workday

1. Building and reinforcing a sustainable culture

1. How to use forcing functions to work remote-first

1. Mental Health: Combating burnout, isolation, and anxiety

1. Jobs

1. Management

1. Remote onboarding

1. Values

1. Collaboration

- 1. Hiring
- 1. Compensation
- 1. Learning and Development
- 1. Self-service
- 1. Informal Communication
- 1. Meetings
- 1. Handbook-first documentation
- 1. Asynchronous workflows
- 1. In-person interactions
- 1. Parenting
- 1. Stories
- 1. Stages of remote work
- 1. Hybrid-remote
- 1. Transitioning/adding remote
- 1. What not to do when implementing remote
- 1. How it works at GitLab
- 1. History
- 1. About

Before an interview is scheduled, guests will be asked to send over an agenda with proposed questions and topics.

Return to the main all-remote page.

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/remote-benefits.md

A brief history of remote work

{.h2}

- 1973: Jack Nilles creates the terms "telecommuting" and "teleworking"
- 1979 Frank Schiff, VP and chief economist of the Committee for Economic Development states that "If 10 percent of those who commute to work each weekday were to start working at home two days each week, this would reduce the volume of such travel by 4 percent" in the Washington Post.
- 1983: IBM runs an experiment and allows 5 employees to work from home. 4 years later nearly 2,000 of its employees were telecommuting.
- 1987: 1.5 million Americans work remotely
- 1991: Wi-Fi boosts the availability of remote work
- 2015: GitLab, Inc. launches with 9 all-remote FTE's
- 2020: COVID-19 accelerates the validity of all-remote work

What is the difference between "remote" and "hybrid"?

Remote: a work arrangement in which employees do not commute to a central place of work

Hybrid: when workers split their time between conventional in-office work and working remotely

Read more about the ten models of remote and hybrid teams.

{{< youtube "Xw-31PZkHOo" >}}

In this video, GitLab Director of Global People Operations Carol Teskey shares her view on the many benefits of all-remote, and the competitive advantages that come along with it.

Benefits of remote work

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<div data-bbox="115 270 892 321" data-label="Text">
<p>Reimagining how one's day can be structured, and how that can easily vary from one 24-hour period to the next, is empowering. The freedom and flexibility that comes with all-remote enables employees to view work in an entirely new light.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 336 869 370" data-label="Text">
<p>Rather than forcing one to build their life about a predefined daily schedule that involves an unavoidable commute, all-remote shifts that responsibility back to the individual.</p>
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<div data-bbox="115 387 883 436" data-label="Text">
<p>A number of studies from the likes of Google, Buffer, FlexJobs, and IWG show that driven individuals who place a high degree of value on autonomy and flexibility can experience new levels of joy and productivity in an all-remote environment.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 453 382 470" data-label="Text">
<p>{{< youtube "tTQAU78QSt8" >}}</p>
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<div data-bbox="115 486 927 536" data-label="Text">
<p>In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of all-remote. For those with friends and family in various locales, team members are empowered to spend time with loved ones, investing in those relationships, without the dread of counting vacation days.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 553 868 603" data-label="Text">
<p>> An added benefit that I didn't anticipate, but have taken full advantage of, is being able to visit friends and family that are in locales that aren't necessarily close to where my home base is. Otherwise, I'd have to take paid time off (PTO) just to visit them.</p>
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<div data-bbox="116 604 134 618" data-label="Text">
<p>></p>
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<div data-bbox="115 618 883 686" data-label="Text">
<p>> I've seen friends and family in Nashville, Raleigh, Iowa, New York, Boston, and all over the west coast. It's not just visiting for a weekend. It's being there for friends, family, birthdays, baby showers, and weddings. Across the board it has been a huge benefit [of all-remote at GitLab]. - Jackie G., Manager, Marketing Programs at GitLab</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="121 702 403 719" data-label="Section-Header">
<h4>Benefits for all-remote employees</h4>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 735 908 785" data-label="Text">
<p>It's important for employees to truly take advantage of the freedoms and possibilities enabled by remote, rather than simply remaining where they are and switching an office desk for a room in their home. This is the core benefit of remote as compared to work-from-home.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 801 885 885" data-label="Text">
<p>Consider relocating to a lower cost-of-living environment, and look to integrate work into life rather than vice-versa. Remote work enables you to optimize for things like superior air quality and medical facilities, a healthier community environment, and better schools for your children. All of this requires premeditated action · to embrace the reality that work is now decoupled from geography.</p>
</div>

In the home, aim to create a dedicated working space (or work from a coworking space, external office, or cafe). It's vital to intentionally separate work and life to prevent burnout. Moreover, don't stop engaging with people. You may not fill your social quota entirely from work interactions, which enables you to pay closer attention to family, neighbors, and community opportunities.

Be intentional about replacing your recovered commute time. Whether it's fitness, cooking, cleaning, spending time with family, or resting, be deliberate about reclaiming that time and using it to improve your overall well-being.

1. You have more flexibility in your daily life (for kids, parents, friends, groceries, sports, deliveries).
1. No more time, stress, or money wasted on a commute (subway and bus fees, gas, car maintenance, tolls, etc.).
1. It's safer. With no commute, there's no risk of getting into an accident traveling to and from work.
1. You can optimize your life for superior air quality and medical facilities, a healthier community environment, and better schools for your children, rather than access to onsite jobs.
1. Reduced interruption stress and increased productivity.
1. Ability to travel to other places without taking vacation (family, fun, etc.).
1. Freedom to relocate, be location independent, or even travel with other remote professionals.
1. Less exposure to germs from sick coworkers.
1. It can be easier to communicate with difficult colleagues remotely, reducing distractions from interpersonal drama or office politics.
1. You can set up and decorate your office or workspace in whatever way works best for you.
1. You can choose your working hours based on when you're most productive.
1. You have the opportunity to meet and work with people from many locations around the world, widening one's view of the world and creating opportunities to learn about new cultures.
1. Onboarding may be less stressful socially.
1. Eating at home is better (sometimes) and cheaper.
1. Taxes can be cheaper in some countries.
1. Work clothes are not required.

From family time to travel plans, there are many examples and stories of how remote work has impacted the lives of GitLab team members around the world.

> "The flexibility makes family life exponentially easier, which reduces stress and makes you more productive and motivated. You can't put a dollar value on it - it's priceless." - Haydn, Regional Sales Director, GitLab

Benefits for all-remote organizations

Remote enables a more diverse and inclusive workforce, greater efficiency in workflows, and broader global coverage in servicing clients. It significantly de-risks a business, making it more resilient in the face of crises and able to maintain continuity regardless of whether an office is open or closed.

Companies may need to create a remote leadership team and invest in manager training. However, there is little debate on whether this is an option. Remote work will soon simply be "work,"

with global flexibility an expectation. Companies which have multiple offices already have teams which are remote to one another, and thus need a solid baseline of remote fluency to operate in optimal fashion.

Limiting your company's recruiting pipeline to a certain geographic region, or sourcing employees who are able and willing to relocate, is a competitive disadvantage.

Not only does this create a less inclusive hiring process which reaches a less diverse set of candidates, it forces your organization to compete primarily on the basis of salary.

1. You're able to hire great people no matter where they live.
 - GitLab has a truly global footprint, with team members in 65+ countries.
1. Employees are more productive with fewer distractions, so long as leadership is supportive in equipping teams with the requisite tools, structure, and culture to thrive.
 - For example, GitLab has a KPI of 65 tickets closed per support staff per month.
1. Increased savings on office costs and compensation (due to hiring in lower-cost regions).
 - GitLab maintains a more balanced payroll than other San Francisco Bay Area colocated companies. Learn more in the Compensation Calculator section of GitLab's handbook.
 - Each function has a new hire location factor target. As an example, marketing targets < 0.72 and finance targets < 0.69. (For reference, San Francisco is 1.00)
 - We have a people group KPI for our average overall location factor to be < 0.65.
1. All-remote naturally attracts self-motivated people.
1. It's easier to quickly grow and scale your company.
 - GitLab does not own/lease office space. As colocated companies scale in size, their spend related to real estate will swell. This not only encompasses office space, but related activities such as security, cleaning, remodeling, etc. It also hampers growth. Hiring too many people in too short a time span will force you to move offices in quick succession, creating massive cost and inefficiency.
1. Employees are increasingly expecting remote work options from their employers.
 - GitLab sees over 3,000 applicants per week for open vacancies. Each applicant is given access to our strategy and an overview of Life at GitLab before they are asked to invest time and energy in applying. We get more qualified applicants due to our transparency, showcased through examples like role description videos hosted on the GitLab Unfiltered YouTube channel.
1. Companies often experience lower employee turnover and higher morale with remote work.
 - GitLab enjoys a strong year-over-year voluntary retention rate. All-remote contributes to our high retention of people, as they're able to take their career with them through life's changes.
1. You have fewer meetings and more focus on results and output of great work.
 - Each meeting which is avoided by asynchronous communication and intentional documentation saves thousands of dollars in wages. Too, the time savings can be repurposed for generating additional value and empowering people to live richer lives as they work more efficiently.
1. You don't have to pay to relocate someone to join your team.
 - GitLab's talent acquisition department tracks cost per hire, which currently does not have a target.
1. With employees located all over the world working asynchronously, contributions can continue even when one time zone's working day is over.
 - GitLab has a people group KPI stating that the percent of sent Slack messages that are not DMs be > 50%.
1. There's also business continuity in the case of local disturbances or natural disasters (e.g. political or weather-related events).

1. Greater flexibility can mean greater diversity in your organization.

Benefits for the world

{{< youtube "BC7Prkm3v3g" >}}

In the GitLab Unfiltered video above, two GitLab colleagues discuss the benefits of living in a lower cost-of-living environment near friends, family, and community.

Research from the University of New Hampshire has found that "35% of rural counties in the United States are experiencing protracted and significant population loss." Speaking to shrinking towns across Europe, a 2016 report from the European Parliamentary Research Service⁵⁸⁶⁶³²) notes that "younger members of society prefer to migrate to more economically vibrant regions and cities in search of better job prospects as, in most of these territories, professional opportunities remain limited and confined to specific fields (e.g. agriculture and tourism)."

We believe all-remote has the power to pause, and perhaps even reverse, these trends of depopulation.

Working remotely gives each person the autonomy to serve in a place that matters to them · a place that has shaped them · contributing significantly to the well-being of a population that may be at risk of losing its foundation, should talent continue to flee to the usual job centers.

1. There's evidence that remote work can reduce the effects of urban crowding for many cities around the world. Some states and countries are even offering incentives to encourage remote work. Here are 13 examples around the world.

1. For global companies, bringing better-paying jobs to low-cost regions has positive economic impacts and works to reverse the trends⁵⁸⁶⁶³²) of depopulation in rural regions.

The competitive advantage for companies that embrace remote work

Remote enables a more diverse and inclusive workforce, greater efficiency in workflows, and broader global coverage in servicing clients. It significantly de-risks a business, making it more resilient in the face of crises and able to maintain continuity regardless of whether an office is open or closed.

Companies may need to create a remote leadership team and invest in manager training. However, there is little debate on whether this is an option. Remote work will soon simply be "work," with global flexibility an expectation. Companies which have multiple offices already have teams which are remote to one another, and thus need a solid baseline of remote fluency to operate in optimal fashion.

Top tier talent, without location being a factor

Limiting your company's recruiting pipeline to a certain geographic region, or sourcing employees who are able and willing to relocate, is a competitive disadvantage.

Not only does this create a less inclusive hiring process which reaches a less diverse set of

candidates, it forces your organization to compete primarily on the basis of salary.

Remote organizations are able to hire great people no matter where they live. For example, GitLab has a truly global footprint, with team members in 65+ countries.

Flexible working hours and availability

With employees located all over the world working asynchronously, contributions can continue even when one time zone's working day is over.

Happy staff and better productivity

Employees are more productive with fewer distractions, so long as leadership is supportive in equipping teams with the requisite tools, structure, and culture to thrive.

Challenges to consider before embracing remote work

Despite all-remote having many advantages, remote work isn't for everyone. It can have disadvantages for employees depending on their lifestyle and work preferences, as well as the organization. In the spirit of transparency, we've outlined potential drawbacks and solutions to these challenges here.

Which is right for your organization?

We're nearing a tipping point with all-remote. Instead of remote teams having to justify why they do it, it's going to be colocated companies having to justify why they don't.

All-remote work wouldn't be possible without the constant evolution of technology, and the tools that enable this type of work are continuously being developed and improved.

Determining eligibility for hybrid or remote work

While job sites and common conversation can lump each remote role into a single category, it's important to realize that not every remote role is created equal. Just as colocated roles need to be evaluated in totality, those seeking to transition into a remote role for the first time should ask certain questions during the interview or evaluation phase.

There are various stages of remote work, which can be easily pictured as a sliding scale. From no-remote to hybrid-remote to all-remote, and all points in between, a remote worker's experience in each setting will likely vary. Below, we're highlighting key topics to cover when seeking an understanding of how you'll be treated in a full-time remote role. Additional questions should be considered depending on your specific scenario and familiarity with the hiring company.

While there are a growing number of freelance gigs which can be completed remotely, this article is centered around full-time remote careers.

GitLab remote work manifesto

All-remote work promotes:

1. Hiring and working from all over the world (instead of from a central location).
1. Flexible working hours (over set working hours).
1. Writing down and recording knowledge (over verbal explanations).
1. Written processes (over on-the-job training).
1. Public sharing of information (over need-to-know access).
1. Opening up documents for editing by anyone (over top-down control of documents).
1. Asynchronous communication (over synchronous communication).
1. The results of impact (over the activity put in).
1. Formal communication channels (over informal communication channels).

> "Remote is not a challenge to overcome. It's a clear business advantage." -Victor, Product Manager, GitLab

GitLab is one of the world's largest all-remote companies with team members located in more than 65 countries around the world.

Our all-remote workforce implementation is featured in The Journal of Organizational Design. It is also the centerpiece of case studies authored by Harvard Business School and INSEAD.

Click around to learn more about what "all-remote" really means, how it works at GitLab, some tips and tricks for remote teams, and resources to learn more.

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

[Return to the main all-remote page.](#)

SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/remote-certification.md

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<div data-bbox="115 718 917 802" data-label="Text">
<p>GitLab is a pioneer in the all-remote space. As one of the largest all-remote companies in the world, we have developed a custom course to test and apply knowledge attained throughout the all-remote section of the handbook. Emerging leaders must quickly learn and deploy remote-first practices and skills while expanding their knowledge of remote management and overall remote fluency.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 817 933 868" data-label="Text">
<p>Presented at a self-directed pace, the GitLab Remote Work Foundation course is designed to give new managers and individual contributors an opportunity to master all-remote business concepts and build key skills in remote subject areas.</p>
</div>
<div data-bbox="115 884 866 902" data-label="Text">
<p>Participants will gain a point of view on all-remote through self-paced learning and reading.</p>
</div>

Course benefits

- 1. Improve your remote fluency
- 1. Build organization, team management, and networking skills in a remote setting
- 1. Understand how GitLab has built and scaled one of the largest all-remote companies
- 1. Develop a framework for your own organization
- 1. Gain full transparency into the processes, policies, and procedures GitLab uses to be successful

Who should complete the course?

This course is ideal for aspiring or new managers, individual contributors, or anyone who is looking to rapidly increase their remote foundational skills and strategic perspective. The course is also ideal for individuals who prefer to complete training at their own pace through reading comprehension and viewing video.

How to access the course

You can access this course on Level Up.

More GitLab courses

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GitLab is actively building new courses and certifications for FY24 and beyond. While we're iterating:

- 1. Enroll in GitLab's Remote Team Management course hosted on Coursera.
- 1. Enroll in GitLab's TeamOps course. TeamOps is an operating model that helps teams maximize productivity, flexibility, and autonomy by managing decisions, information, and tasks more efficiently.

Questions

If you have questions, please reach out to our Learning & Development team at learning@gitlab.com.

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SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/remote-compensation.md

On this page, we're detailing how compensation works in a global all-remote company.

How do you pay people?

When you open your hiring pipeline to practically every nation on the planet, you get questions like "How do you pay people?"

While there are certain complexities to paying team members who are spread across the globe, we believe that it's worthwhile. Being an all-remote company enables us to hire the world's best talent, not just the best talent from a few cities.

{{< youtube "Yr2do8A38r0" >}}

In the above GitLab Unfiltered video, GitLab co-founder Sid Sijbrandij discusses the logistics of hiring remote team members with Proof CEO Daniel Aisen.

Compensating people in a variety of countries isn't easy, and there's no blanket solution. However, as GitLab grows, it's able to incorporate in more countries. This allows us to be a traditional employer, paying local team members directly.

For countries where that's not yet possible, we oftentimes hire professional employment organizations to serve as the employer of record (EOR) in order to facilitate payments. In other cases, we hire new team members as contractors.

We continually look at where our team is growing, which guides us in prioritizing where to incorporate next.

What currency do you use?

The preference is for team members and future team members to be paid in their local currency. However, there may be instances where this is not possible and another currency may be chosen by the team member. For the full list of countries where GitLab can pay using local currency, visit the Compensation section of our Handbook.

Why do you pay local rates?

GitLab endeavors to pay local rates as opposed to paying a San Francisco wage to everyone in the company, regardless of their location.

Our co-founder Sid Sijbrandij discusses this in a blog post entitled "Why GitLab pays local rates."

> If we pay everyone the San Francisco wage for their respective roles, our compensation costs would increase greatly, and we would be forced to hire a lot fewer people. Then we wouldn't be able to produce as much as we would like. If we started paying everyone the lowest rate possible, we would not be able to retain the people we want to keep.

Particularly in comparison to companies in cities with high costs of living, such as London, San Francisco, Singapore, Sydney, etc., an all-remote company realizes a notable set of advantages by hiring brilliant minds in locales with lower costs of living.

Funds that would be reserved for salaries · necessary to compete in hot labor markets · can be redirected to areas such as research and development (R&D), acquisitions, and hiring more people.

These additional investments can be made simply by lowering a company's overall spend on compensation, but only if a company is willing to hire in locales where a dollar goes farther than the SF Benchmark.

How can other companies move to a remote compensation model?

To talk through Best Practices for Remote Compensation, GitLab partnered with Compaas to outline how to get started recommendations, and pitfalls when transitioning to a remote friendly or remote only compensation model.

How do you decide how much to pay people?

Plainly, we want our compensation to be at a level where we can recruit and retain people who meet our requirements. A far more elaborate explanation can be found in the Compensation Principles section of GitLab's Handbook.

Deciding how much we pay people who live and work in a multitude of regions across the globe is a continual process. Iteration and Transparency are values at GitLab, and both apply to compensation calculations.

{{< youtube "CgQNffuHrc?start=34" >}}

In the above video, which was streamed live on GitLab's YouTube channel, GitLab Compensation & Benefits Manager Brittany Rohde discusses a variety of all-remote compensation topics with Microverse COO Juan José Mata.

Understanding GitLab's Compensation Calculator

All-remote companies should consider a public compensation calculator to remove guesswork. When you open roles to a global talent pool, this allows candidates to get familiar with compensation expectations prior to applying, which creates efficiencies in the hiring process.

Colocated companies are generally relieved of this burden, as anyone applying to a role requiring them to reside in a given city can do their own research on market rates for that locale.

Iterating on compensation

During the fourth quarter of each year, GitLab conducts a compensation review to ensure all team members are paid based on market data in the compensation calculator. This is not a Cost of Living Adjustment, but instead a review of the market changes.

For all-remote companies looking to enact a similar process, please study our Annual Compensation Review.

Factoring the factors

For GitLab team members · with the exception of Executive Compensation and anyone on a quota · the following factors are factored into their salary. We invite other all-remote companies to study this formula if considering how to pay a truly global team.

Your salary = SF benchmark x Location Factor x Level Factor x Compa Ratio x Exchange Rate

What role does experience play?

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A person's background and experience influences their value to a company, regardless of how the company is organized. In an all-remote setting where a company pays local rates, experience can play an outsized role in a team member's cash compensation.

It's important to evaluate experience not based on years in the workforce, but rather, demonstrated ability to drive projects and deliverables from the position description to completion. In an all-remote setting, this can include experience operating and managing in a work environment where you do not regularly meet direct reports, clients, and peers on an in-person basis.

While compa ratios at colocated companies typically focus on experience in the role, all-remote compa ratios must consider more nuance · elements such as an ability to communicate well virtually and operate effectively in an asynchronous setting.

Learn more about GitLab's Compa Ratios.

How do stock options factor in?

As many other organizations do, GitLab provides equity grants in the form of Incentive Stock Options (ISOs) and Non-Qualified Stock Options (NSOs).

The difference in these two types of grants are, generally, as follows: ISOs are issued to US employees and carry a special form of tax treatment recognized by the US Internal Revenue Service (IRS). NSOs are granted to contractors and non-US employees.

You can learn more in the Stock Options section of the Handbook.

{{% include "includes/isthisadviceanygoodremote.md" %}}

Contribute your lessons

GitLab believes that all-remote is the future of work, and remote companies have a shared responsibility to show the way for other organizations who are embracing it. If you or your company has an experience that would benefit the greater world, consider creating a merge request and adding a contribution to this page.

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SECTION: company/culture/all-remote/remote-history.md

On this page, we're curating important historical moments and milestones that have shaped and furthered remote work globally.

Nikola Tesla

Nikola Tesla was an engineer and inventor, best known for his contributions and experiments linked to electrical systems.

> "Nikola Tesla in 1926: Wireless will eliminate distance and allow individuals to communicate instantly, as perfectly as though we were face to face.

>

> The whole earth will be converted into a huge brain.

>

> The instrument? A man will be able to carry one in his vest pocket."

Source: Garry Tan on X (Twitter)

In a 1926 issue of Collier's magazine, Tesla shared a number of predictions for the future. In forecasting a telephone which could be carried i